The bone of contention in the western section is the boundary that extends eastwards from the Karakoram Pass to the Changchenmo Valley that lies to the south. This was the traditional line that divided the Ladakh region in Jammu and Kashmir from Sinkiang and Tibet, both of which are now under Chinese control. India claims that the huge expanse of the Aksai Chin lies south of the Kunlun mountain range and is therefore an integral part of its territory. Geographically part of the Tibetan Plateau and the Changtang, the region is almost uninhabited and sees little precipitation. Historically, however, the 38,000-square-kilometre Aksai Chin was a part of the Himalayan kingdom of Ladakh until it was annexed by Kashmir in the nineteenth century.

Even by the standards of the Karakorams, the Aksai Chin region is extremely remote, and the boundary between Ladakh and Tibet was never formally settled. After the Amritsar Treaty formally created the kingdom of Jammu and Kashmir, the British abrogated to themselves the responsibility of the state's security, making themselves responsible for Kashmir's northern and eastern borders with Sinkiang and Tibet. The first British attempt, Cunningham's Ladakh Border Commission, failed to delineate the eastern border between Ladakh and Tibet and the northern boundaries between Kashmir and Sinkiang in 1847, which left the British no choice but to rely on an earlier treaty, signed on 16-17 September 1842, between Ladakh and Tibet, which was one of non-aggression rather than a boundary treaty.

The 1842 treaty officially marked the end of hostilities between the two sides: Zorawar Singh's ambitious Dogra venture into Tibet and an equally unsuccessful retaliation that brought the Tibetans to Leh. The Persian and Tibetan texts both agree that India 'shall remain in possession of the limits of boundaries of Ladakh and the neighbours subordinate to it, in accordance with the old customs, and there shall be no transgression and no interference in the country beyond the old-established frontiers'. The Tibetan text in Kashmir's possession was of the same tenor.

What were the old established frontiers? In 1878, when the Chinese once again established their control over Sinkiang, they created a customs post north of Shahidula implying that they considered the Kuen Lun as outside their jurisdiction. However, seeing that there was no effective Kashmiri governance in this area, the Chinese occupied Shahidula in 1890